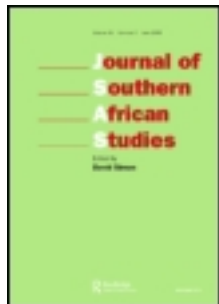


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### The great war and Chewa society in Malawi

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# *The Great War and Chewa Society in Malawi*

MELVIN E. PAGE

The Chewa of Malawi's central region have proved to be a most resilient people. Their political structure has always tended to disintegration, in part owing to the dual clan, matrilineal nature of chiefly succession. This situation was complicated in the nineteenth century by challenges to Chewa political and economic power from various African forces, most notably Ngoni and Yao settlers and Swahili traders. Since the 1880s the Chewa have also had to contend with the growing involvement of European missionaries and government officials in their affairs.<sup>1</sup> Yet through all of this the Chewa have not only survived, but have also spread their influence throughout present day Malawi.

Although much Chewa political power was undermined by the Ngoni and the Yao, a significant remnant of Chewa authority was preserved by the chieftanship of Mwase Kasungu. Using their position astride trade routes with Lake Malawi and beyond, successive Mwases were able to forge alliances alternately with Swahili and Portuguese traders and to resist the pressure of Ngoni raids. As the major outpost of resistance to the Ngoni, Mwase Kasungu's territory became a refuge for Chewa displaced in areas to the south. The full assertion of British power, however, upset the delicate balance which the Mwases had so carefully worked to maintain, leading to their decline. In the *pax Britannia* which followed, the Chewa were nonetheless able to reassert their cultural dominance over central Malawi.

<sup>1</sup> The only full account of Chewa history available in English is S. J. Ntara, *The History of the Chewa*, trans. W. S. Kamphandira Jere, with commentary by Harry W. Langworthy (Wiesbaden: Franz Steiner Verlag, 1973). For a consideration of the difficulties of using the various editions of Ntara's *Mbiri ya Achewa*, see my review of this translation: Melvin E. Page, *Anthropos*, 70 (1975), pp. 968-9. For more detail on specific topics in Chewa history see: J. M. Schoffeleers, 'The Meaning and Use of the Name *Malawi* in Oral Traditions and Precolonial Documents', in *The Early History of Malawi*, ed B. Pachai (London: Longmans, 1972), pp. 91-103; and Harry W. Langworthy, 'Central Malawi in the 19th Century', in *From Nyasaland to Malawi*, ed R. J. Macdonald (Nairobi: East African Publishing House, 1975), pp. 1-43.

Even though a major share of the credit for Chewa survival into the colonial era belongs to the Mwase Kasungu chieftancy, much of the reason must also be sought in the basic strengths of Chewa society itself. Though no doubt influenced by the new Ngoni (and less frequently Yao) ruling classes, Chewa cultural continuity remained unbroken throughout the central region, up to the present day. One reason for this cultural survival can be found in the importance of local, village authority in Chewa life. The splitting of lineages and villages, and consequent local migration, have been constant factors in Chewa history, tending toward a greater local focus in community life. Such patterns tended to undermine not only a succession of Chewa kingships, but Ngoni political authority as well.<sup>2</sup>

Another, perhaps more important factor, in the preservation of Chewa culture was religion. Though normally one of the prerogatives and sources of a king's power, among the Chewa there were two religious forces which mitigated against this. One was the shrine of Makewana, a centre of spirit mediumship. Though allied with various kings and their lineages, the shrine was not under royal control, indeed sometimes undermined it. Under Ngoni political hegemony, the shrine remained a Chewa preserve, removed from political control by the new leaders.<sup>3</sup> The other religious force was the *nyau*, a secret society which made considerable demands on its members. This cult was deeply rooted among the commoners in Chewa society. Although nominally supported by the chiefs, the *nyau* had its own leadership and maintained a completely separate jurisdiction over its members when they were involved in society activities. This basis made the *nyau* not only a popular refuge during the period of Ngoni rule, but also focal point of defiance to the new authority.<sup>4</sup>

Even though the British colonial authorities had succeeded in undermining the power of the Mwase Kasungu chieftanship by 1896, Chewa local authority and, more important, religious institutions were maintained into the colonial era. With Ngoni power checked, and Europeans few in number, Chewa institutions thrived. The demands of the colonial administration, once their authority had been established, were initially modest. Taxes were light, payable in kind, and only enforced in areas near the government stations; of these, in 1910 there were just six in the entire

<sup>2</sup> See Langworthy commentary, *History of the Chewa*, p. xv, and also Langworthy, 'Central Malawi', pp. 3-6.

<sup>3</sup> Harry W. Langworthy, 'Chewa or Malawi Political Organization in the Precolonial Era', in *Early History of Malawi*, pp. 111-12.

<sup>4</sup> Matthew Schoffeleers and I. Linden, 'The Resistance of the Nyau Societies to the Roman Catholic Missions in Colonial Malawi', in *The Historical Study of African Religion*, eds T. O. Ranger and Isaria Kimambo (London: Heinemann, 1972), pp. 252-5, 257-9; Ian Linden, with Jane Linden, *Catholics, Peasants, and Chewa Resistance in Nyasaland, 1889-1939* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1974), pp. 117-18. In the limited areas of Yao authority, the force of Islam appears to have undermined *nyau* survival.

central region. Other than taxes, the colonial government's sole demand was the absence of challenges to its position; at evincing acquiescence the Chewa had already become expert.

The only real challenges to Chewa culture in the first decades of European rule came from Christian missions. Arriving in the 1890s and the first decade of the twentieth century, first Dutch Reformed and later Roman Catholic outposts were established in the central region. Unlike the British colonial authorities—or the Ngoni—the missionaries were not interested in simple political power. They were interested in 'souls', a preoccupation which would involve a direct confrontation with Chewa traditional values. Prior to the First World War, however, the missionaries in the central region were more concerned in building their stations and promoting education, secular as much as religious. It was only later that severe challenges to Christian influence and mission presence arose among the Chewa, who feared growing pressure on their cultural traditions from the new, European faith.<sup>5</sup>

In general, prior to 1914 there were only minimal pressures on the Chewa as a result of the European presence. If anything, colonial rule had brought a greater stability to Chewa life than the people had known in over half a century.<sup>6</sup> Nonetheless, some expressions of dissatisfaction with British presence were evident in the central region, often accompanied by predictions of further strains upon the fabric of African life. In 1907, following the appearance of a fiery meteor, a prophetess from Mozambique, Chanjiri, attracted a large following among the Chewa. She denounced Europeans, claiming they would destroy traditional African life, and promised that if people would follow her she would 'free them from the tax of the English and Portuguese' and lead them through the imminent conflagration which would accomplish this.<sup>7</sup> Although her influence was diminished after she was exiled far into Portuguese territory, Chanjiri's predictions drew attention to an undercurrent of opinion throughout the Nyasaland protectorate which reflect an unease with the potentialities of European rule.<sup>8</sup>

The comparative calm of these early colonial years came to end with World War One, an experience which more than justified the shadowy apprehensions felt earlier. Almost immediately after war was declared in

<sup>5</sup> This process is fully discussed by Linden, *Catholics*, passim. An extensive study of African and mission interaction, such as the Lindens have made for the Roman Catholics, has yet to be undertaken concerning Dutch Reformed work in central Malawi; for a brief overview, however, see J. L. Pretorius, 'An introduction to the history of the Dutch Reformed Church Mission in Malawi', in *Early History of Malawi*, pp. 365–83.

<sup>6</sup> See Langworthy, 'Central Malawi', p. 41.

<sup>7</sup> *Zambesi Industrial Mission Occasional Paper* (July–December 1909), p. 12.

<sup>8</sup> For a fuller development of this theme see Melvin E. Page, 'Malawians in the Great War and After, 1914–1925', unpubl. PhD diss., Michigan State University, 1977, pp. 14–23.

Europe, demands came for African service. Men were needed as soldiers to swell the *askari* ranks of the King's African Rifles and defend Nyasaland against attacks mounted from across the border in German East Africa. Many more were required as *tengatenga*, the carriers who moved military supplies and food along the vital communications network which ran through the country. Government officials were energetic in finding the necessary manpower. They widely advertised the advantages of military life and thus succeeded in attracting men into the relatively well-paid ranks of the KAR. Finding sufficient carriers was much more difficult, however, so African chiefs and headmen were called upon to turn out men for the *tengatenga* legions. Missionaries, too, were expected to help in finding men to meet the increasing labour needs.

Among the Chewa, and throughout the country, people reacted to these demands with incredulity. In few places, certainly not in the central region, had the colonial government previously made such requirements of the people and their leaders. Everywhere men ran into the bush to avoid being selected for service as military labourers. Chewa villagers frequently quarrelled with their headmen, even with their chiefs, hoping to prevent their leaders' acquiescence. Working for the chief himself was an accepted part of the reciprocity which formed the basis of his authority. But turning over unwilling labourers to the Europeans was, for the Chewa, nearly unprecedented. Where chiefs did comply with colonial demands, some were threatened by their subjects; at least one headman's house was burned to the ground by his irate followers. A few chiefs responded by making outrageous promises to their subjects; others merely relied on local European officials to make those selected serve. None undertook any serious resistance.<sup>9</sup>

In fact, the only serious African attempts to resist war recruitment took place largely outside the central region. One of these was the refusal of the northern Ngoni chief Chitunga Jere to send carriers for the war effort. Openly defiant, he was removed from office by the district Resident after a government show of force. In the south, a much more serious affair was the well known abortive rebellion of John Chilembwe. To be sure, the motivations of Chilembwe and his followers were complex, even confused. There is no doubt, though, that the coming of the Great War and particularly the demands for men was a major factor in prompting the uprising. Despite some initial successes, Chilembwe's rebels were defeated and Chilembwe himself killed. In Ncheu, the attempt of Philipo Chinyama, an Ngoni pastor of the small Seventh-Day Baptist Church, to involve the

<sup>9</sup> The importance of military recruitment of both *askari* and *tengatenga* is explored in Melvin E. Page, 'The War of *Thangata*: Nyasaland and the East African Campaign, 1914-1919', *Journal of African History*, 19 (1978), pp. 87-100.

central region in Chilembwe's scheme was forestalled even before it began.<sup>10</sup>

In the wake of such resistance, the government's chief secretary wrote to all district Residents, noting firmly that any African unrest must be avoided. 'The position', he directed, 'should be quietly explained to the chiefs and headmen and the fullest assurance may be given that men engaged as carriers or labourers will not be required to fight'. Early the next year the chief secretary again urged restraint and the exercise of 'the personal influence of the Residents' in recruitment. His expressed hope was that sufficient men could be procured 'without obliging the Government to resort to its statutory powers of compulsion'.<sup>11</sup> But the needs of the military did not diminish. Rather, they became almost voracious as British forces in 1916 invaded German East Africa from Nyasaland and Northern Rhodesia. Brigadier General Edward Northey, commander of the operation, was soon demanding that Nyasaland's Governor, Sir George Smith, provide 'more carriers and more carriers and more carriers'.<sup>12</sup> Nor was this the only demand.

In addition to direct service with the military as soldiers and carriers, people were required to produce food and transport it to the lake. In the central region, where the Chewa had long been harvesting an almost annual agricultural surplus, government food purchases were especially heavy. Despite the absence of some manpower, Chewa agriculturalists attempted to make the most of this new opportunity and in the process laid the foundation for future cash-cropping.<sup>13</sup> Still more men—and women—were needed to carry the crops to the lakeshore for transport on steamers going north to the troops. Others worked on the roads, constructed new buildings, cut firewood for the steamers, and performed longshoremen's tasks at various harbours and anchorages on the lake.

The meagre opportunity provided through the sale of foodstuffs did not offset the tremendous dislocations the Chewa suffered as a result of the

<sup>10</sup> The Chilembwe rebellion has been the subject of considerable study. For appropriate citations and a consideration of Chilembwe's revolt in the context of World War One, see Page, 'Malawians in the Great War', pp. 22–3, 31–5, 56–60 and 247–8. The only study of the Chimtunga Jere incident is H. W. Mhoni, 'An Assessment of the Resistance and Banishment of Chimtunga Jere, 1914–1918', unpubl. University of Malawi history seminar paper, 1973–4.

<sup>11</sup> Chief Secretary to district Residents, circular letters of 7 October 1915 and 16 February 1916, GOA 2/4/3 and NSB 1/2/3, Malawi National Archives [hereafter MNA].

<sup>12</sup> Northey to Smith, 14 December 1916, GOA 2/3/1, MNA.

<sup>13</sup> See Martin Chanock, 'Notes for an Agricultural History of Malawi', *Rural Africana*, 20 (Spring 1973), pp. 28–9. Interview 122, Olivia Tambala, 1 August 1973. Details of this and other oral historical sources (interviews and questionnaires) cited in this paper can be found in my doctoral dissertation, Page, 'Malawians in the Great War', pp. 260–5. The value of this type of oral historical data, largely of the personal reminiscence type, for recent Chewa history has been noted by Harry W. Langworthy, 'Understanding Malawi's Pre-Colonial History', *Society of Malawi Journal*, 23, 1(1970), 45.

growing manpower demands. Not only were their chiefs unable to resist the increasing erosion of royal power, they also watched the undermining of village life which had heretofore been a particular strength of Chewa culture. Government recruiters entered villages at will, day or night, literally capturing men and dragging them off for service. Those who tried to run away were tracked down. If that failed, their womenfolk were not infrequently seized as hostages, to be released only when the men gave themselves up and went off to war. The African messengers and police on whom the task of recruiting fell dared not let up on the pressure lest they be punished. 'There was terror everywhere and people did not feel safe.'<sup>14</sup>

Such odious military labour demands, and the civil oppression which they engendered, clearly called for extraordinary measures. At least some of the Chewa found an answer in the *nyau* societies, whose basic structure was utilized as a means of opposition not only to recruitment, but also to European institutions generally. The overt expression of the societies was in their dances, performed at important transitional ceremonies, especially funerals and female initiation. During the dances some of the men put on masks representing animals and other figures, thereby becoming subsumed in their spirit identities. In such circumstances a dancer's behaviour was no longer controlled by the usual societal sanctions; a special set of *nyau* rules applied instead. Likewise, the places where the societies met and where they kept their masks and other paraphernalia were subject to special restrictions; only members might enter, and trespassers were subject to severe punishments, originally death.<sup>15</sup> It was these special rules and sanctions of the *nyau* which became important for those wishing to avoid wartime recruitment for military labour.

Threatened with imminent seizure, *nyau* members would escape from their villages and hide in special caves found in the hills, especially of Dedza district, where the societies' masks were stored. Unable to flee into the foothills, some men instead slipped into nearby graveyards which were also areas within the *nyau* sphere of influence.<sup>16</sup> Others made their own hiding places in the bush, digging small holes about three feet deep and about one and a half feet in diameter. The men would crawl into these *machemba* and then don masks or other disguises. Occasionally they would appear

<sup>14</sup> Questionnaire NK/7, Chief Malengachanzi, 18 April 1973.

<sup>15</sup> Schoffeleers and Linden, 'Nyau', pp. 257-9; M. G. Marwick, 'Notes on Some Chewa Rituals', *African Studies*, 27(1968), 6; W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Notes on Chewa Tribal Law', *Nyasaland Journal*, 1, 3(1948), 63. I am especially grateful to Professor Schoffeleers for numerous conversations and communications which have aided measurably in the analysis of *nyau* activity during the Great War.

<sup>16</sup> Questionnaires: DZ/16, Lilifodi Kadiguduli, 14 April 1974; DZ/45, Charlesi Mbemba, 13 September 1974; NC/22, F. K. Cheketeni, 18 September 1974. The value of, and cautions concerning, oral historical data in dealing with 'popular history' subjects such as the *nyau* have been noted by Langworthy, 'Understanding Malawi's Pre-Colonial History', p. 45.

camouflaged as ordinary bush foliage. More frequently seen were head-dresses of chicken feathers or masks representing other animals; all of these were standard *nyau* dance equipment.<sup>17</sup>

Whether in mountain caves, graveyards, or their own small holes, these men were counting on the special position of the *nyau* to protect them. All of these attempts at evasion involved a conscious evoking of *nyau* privilege and sacred immunity. The caves were special places, open only to members, where the men would change into their performance costumes and assume their spirit identities. Though not designed as places of refuge, they were ideal for that purpose since anyone revealing the location of the caves, as well as any trespassers, would be harshly dealt with. Graveyards, too, were sacred precincts; some groups used them as places to store their paraphernalia. In all cases, however, it was the societies which controlled the spirits found there and who presided over funerary rites. Thus it was the *nyau* who also controlled access to the graveyards themselves. Society members could, therefore, move more easily into those sacred areas than the rest of the population; once inside, they were also immune from the punishments which awaited any strangers found there.

In fact, the *nyau* monitored much of the daily traffic which passed through Chewa areas, frequently collecting tribute from those whom they might coerce into paying. Especially when chiefs and headmen had shown an inability to control the situation, it was the *nyau* which dominated village life. Many of the government's African recruiters were actually society members, and it was only their position as *nyau* initiates which permitted them to move about in the region.<sup>18</sup> Their membership vows, however, required that they help their brothers in need; neglecting this duty would bring them before a *nyau* court.<sup>19</sup> Other society members counted on this duty to protect them as they hid in the caves and graveyards. Similarly, they used *nyau* symbols to identify themselves as they hid in the *machemba* which they had made. Thus it was the *nyau* rules, and the concomitant suspension of other societal controls, which many Chewa counted on to protect them from recruitment for the war effort.

Just how successful this clever ploy was is difficult to determine. Clearly it did not stop recruiting. Many non-members were forced to serve, and not all those who belonged to the societies could avoid service given the extraordinary demands which the government made for men. Even today there is a great reluctance among the Chewa to discuss *nyau* activity, a

<sup>17</sup> Questionnaires: DZ/31, Simon Njobvu, 3 August 1974; DZ/37, Solomoni Gangata, 10 August 1974; DZ/40, Patrick Gunda Kuyendakwina, 19 August 1974.

<sup>18</sup> Questionnaires: DZ/49, Mateyo Kwayela Mbewe, 27 September 1974; NC/7, Jonasi Zaonde, 10 August 1974; NC/20, Zeffati Khinda, 29 August 1974.

<sup>19</sup> R. H. Murray (Provincial Commissioner, Lilongwe) to Chief Secretary, [?], 1929, S2/23/29, MNA.



factor which complicates any analysis such as this. Evidence from Dedza district, however, suggests most society members in that area at least attempted to use their *nyau* membership to avoid service.<sup>20</sup> Their success may indeed have been great, especially as their techniques became more highly developed near the end of the war.

*Table of Malawian Military Labour by Districts*

| <i>District<br/>sub-district</i> | <i>1918 Administrative Census</i> |                               |                                     |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
|                                  | <i>Adult<br/>Males</i>            | <i>Military<br/>Labourers</i> | <i>% on<br/>Military<br/>Labour</i> |
| Lower Shire                      | 7,496                             | 1,362                         | 18.2                                |
| Ruo                              | 7,295                             | 1,147                         | 15.7                                |
| West Shire                       | 5,074                             | 105                           | 2.1                                 |
| Blantyre                         | 25,056                            | 6,542                         | 26.1                                |
| Chiradzulu                       | 8,678                             | 1,460                         | 16.8                                |
| Mulanje                          | 16,214                            | 149                           | .9                                  |
| Zomba                            | 21,143                            | 3,600                         | 17.0                                |
| Upper Shire                      | 15,520                            | 8,135                         | 52.4                                |
| Liwonde                          | 9,899                             | 7,580                         | 76.6                                |
| South Nyasa                      | 34,017                            | 18,615                        | 54.7                                |
| Lilongwe                         | 21,923                            | 9,216                         | 42.0                                |
| Dedza                            | 25,607                            | 4,288                         | 16.7                                |
| Dowa                             | 25,059                            | 8,005                         | 31.9                                |
| Marimba                          | 11,610                            | 3,700                         | 31.9                                |
| Ngara                            | 7,430                             | 2,627                         | 35.4                                |
| West Nyasa                       | 11,988                            | 1,956                         | 16.3                                |
| Mombera's                        | 23,252                            | 3,005                         | 12.9                                |
| North Nyasa                      | 15,395                            | 6,234                         | 40.5                                |
| Totals                           | 292,656                           | 87,726                        | 29.9                                |

Source: Malawi National Archives, NSB 1/2/5. As with most colonial statistics of this period, these figures must be treated with some caution. They are used here only for the purpose of general comparison, not as a fully accurate indication of Malawian population and war manpower.

A protectorate-wide survey (see above), made in early 1918, indicates that Dedza district had one of the lower percentages of its adult male population on military labour service. Explanations for the low percentages elsewhere are relatively easy to find. In the southern reaches of Nyasaland—the Lower Shire, Ruu, West Shire, and Mulanje districts—fewer men were recruited as they had to travel too far just to begin work on the major communication links. Zomba and West Nyasa districts had traditionally been areas of heavy recruitment for the King's African Rifles and remained so throughout the war; there, men were encouraged to become *askari* and consequently *tengatenga* levies lagged. Mombera's district and Chiradzulu sub-district were special cases. They had been the scenes of the Chitunga and

<sup>20</sup> Questionnaire DZ/34, Mambo Ng'oma, 6 August 1974.

Chilembwe attempts to resist government service. It was only in these areas, therefore, that government efforts to avoid further African unrest were seriously put into practice, limiting the numbers actually recruited. This leaves only Dedza district. And there the oral historical data is strongest concerning *nyau* resistance to the military labour draft.

Why Dedza stands out among the four districts of the central region, both in the percentage of men on *tengatenga* service and in *nyau* anti-recruitment efforts, is difficult to explain. It may be that the particular societies operating in Dedza were organized differently than elsewhere in the central region, or that their objectives were not precisely the same as other groups.<sup>21</sup> The Dedza groups do appear to have been much more likely to use hillside caves as storage places for their masks and costumes than other Chewa *nyau* societies. In addition, there is some evidence that the *nyau* had an exceptionally strong position vis-a-vis the chiefs in Dedza, although whether this antedated their wartime activities or was a result of them is not entirely clear.<sup>22</sup> Among the Chewa population in the district, though, the *nyau* are remembered as being particularly powerful during the war years. Thus they are recalled as having been 'hard-hearted', an appellation also given to Europeans of strong will and forceful disposition.<sup>23</sup>

This image of the *nyau* had carried throughout Chewa society by the end of the war, giving the societies a special place in the life of the district. As had been expected, *nyau* dancers had performed at funeral ceremonies throughout the war, continuing to do so after the conflict was finally over.<sup>24</sup> Less expected, perhaps, but equally clear, the dances were undertaken as a means of celebration, an expression of the victory which both death and homecoming marked in the special context of the war. The *nyau* became an expression of a greater kind of transition and, as such, marked a new and at least partially political role of the societies.<sup>25</sup>

In the hectic years of 1918 and 1919, such subtleties were lost upon European missionaries and government officials. They were able, however, to discern the ambiguities felt by many Chewa concerning the end of the war, especially in the wake of a difficult mobilization. Nyasaland's European newspaper caught the mood, urging that 'the native mind should see some outward and visible sign of victory'.<sup>26</sup> Taking up the suggestion,

<sup>21</sup> It is known that differences did exist between various *nyau* societies in different localities; see Schoffeleers and Linden, 'Nyau', pp. 257-61.

<sup>22</sup> Questionnaire DZ/47, Sonthi Chisale, 15 September 1974.

<sup>23</sup> Questionnaire DZ/49, Mateyo Kwayela Mbewe, 27 September 1974.

<sup>24</sup> Interviews: 116, Amos Isaac, 14 July 1973; 119, Village Headman Malomo, 7 August 1973.

<sup>25</sup> Questionnaires: DW/7, Paulo Golovana Fulatira, 17 April 1974; NC/18, George Manage, 27 August 1974; DZ/30, Yatesi Kusamba, 2 August 1974.

<sup>26</sup> *Nyasaland Times*, 21, 51 (19 December 1918), 2. Africans were, in fact, concerned that the war might not really be over; interview 79, Mlekano Wadi Kalisinge, 4 April 1973. A full

the acting Governor requested and was authorized an expenditure of £750 for 'a certain amount of demonstration . . . to bring the fact of victory home to the native'.<sup>27</sup> The key feature of the celebrations, and the one which most clearly had the desired effect upon Malawians, was a series of bonfires on hills throughout the country. 'They just lit fire all over the highest hills in the world,' recalled one man who lived along the southern lakeshore. The fires, though, were visible in all parts of the country<sup>28</sup> and as signs of victory were extremely apt. Among the Chewa fire had long been an indicator of transition and could widely be interpreted as 'a symbolic statement about the beginning of a new era'. In such a context, fire might also be associated with the transitional importance of *nyau* ceremonies.<sup>29</sup> Though they may not have intended to do so, and there is no clear evidence to suggest such a conscious realization,<sup>30</sup> the European celebrations were likely taken by Africans in the central region as confirmation of the newly significant and enlarged role of the *nyau* societies.

Once the celebrations were over and the war was behind them, the Chewa attempted to return to normal lives. But they found this was impossible. The Great War had brought changes to their culture which nothing in their previous experience could match—not the Ngoni warriors and their political hegemony, nor the British defeat of Mwase Kasungu, not even the arrival of the Christian missionaries. Nothing had altered their pattern of existence as World War One had done. Of course, the war brought nothing new; rather, it demonstrated the extreme intensity to which European involvement might come. The demands of the war also showed that even the missions would support the most outrageous government programmes and that Chewa—indeed all African—political power was helpless in the face of colonial rule, once it had been fully extended throughout the protectorate.

In the bitterness which such realizations engendered, Africans sought ways to express their dissatisfaction. For some, chiefly those with some European education, there were native associations which petitioned the government, with little success, for a redress of grievances. Amongst the Yao, a resurgence of Islam took on elements of an anti-European reaction.

discussion of this fear is contained in Melvin E. Page, 'The Great War in Malawian Memory', *The Centennial Review*, 21(1977), pp. 321–32.

<sup>27</sup> Minute by Colonial Office official W. A. Bottomley, 28 January 1919, on Sir Hector L. Duff (acting Governor) to Colonial Office, 23 January 1919, CO 525/82, Public Record Office, London.

<sup>28</sup> Interview 89, Madi Wadi Selemani, 12 April 1973. Also interview 116, Amos Isaac, 14 July 1973.

<sup>29</sup> Schoffeleers, 'The Meaning and Use of the Name *Malawi*', pp. 98–9. The quotation cited refers specifically to the precolonial political ascendancy of the Phiri clan in Chewa areas, but it is equally applicable in the present context.

<sup>30</sup> The initial suggestion seems to have come from the *Nyasaland Times*, 21, 51(19 December 1918), 2; however, nothing in the newspaper's proposal would indicate appreciation of the symbolic significance of the fires.

In other areas a new dance mode borrowed from east Africa, the *beni*, spread rapidly, its stylized mockery of European position a quick outlet for African frustrations. For the Chewa, however, the principal focus of group reaction came through the traditional *nyau* societies. Not just in Dedza district, but throughout the central region, there was a marked increase in *nyau* activity during the 1920s. Since government officials were scarce after the war, many having gone on leave or taken positions with the government of the new mandate of Tanganyika Territory, the missions were the most direct manifestation of European civilization the Chewa confronted in the immediate post-war world. It was against the missions, therefore, that the *nyau* societies seemed to direct their increasing anti-European feeling.<sup>31</sup>

Complaining vociferously to government authorities concerning the *nyau* organizations, especially their apparent absence from all usual social sanctions, the missions tried to paint them as 'certainly . . . opposed to European influence'.<sup>32</sup> While some district and provincial officers were sympathetic, they did not share the grave concern about the societies as 'the strongest and most aggressive enemy of civilization and education in the land', a picture which the churchmen tried to present.<sup>33</sup> Failing to arouse colonial officials to action with direct appeals, the missionaries turned to a media campaign in Britain itself, painting the *nyau* as 'devil dancers of terror' and likening their activities to those of John Chilembwe and his followers.<sup>34</sup> That the societies may have abused their new position by cruelly treating other Africans, particularly Christian converts, the missionaries have been proven correct. But that there was little truly seditious the colonial officials were probably right. In the context of the war and its aftermath, however, there can be little doubt that the *nyau* societies represented the most significant traditional expression of general discontent, not only among the Chewa, but probably throughout the protectorate.<sup>35</sup>

<sup>31</sup> Questionnaires: LL/2, Mr Yohane, 8 April 1973; MC/9, Chikani Mtali, 21 April 1973. Acting Central Province Commissioner to Chief Secretary, 23 June 1922, and 14 August 1922, including enclosures, NC 1/21/2, MNA; H.E. Munby, 'Heathenism in the Hill Districts', *Central Africa*, 41(1923), pp. 77-8; Schoffeleers and Linden, 'Nyau', pp. 260-8. The reactions outside Chewa areas are described in Page, 'Malawians in the Great War', pp. 237-45.

<sup>32</sup> M. Guillemé, 'Notes on Zinyao', 15 May 1924, NC 1/21/2, MNA.

<sup>33</sup> Rev W. H. Murray to W. Kirby Green (Central Province Commissioner), 14 September 1922, and Acting Province Commissioner to Chief Secretary, 23 June 1922, both NC 1/21/2, MNA.

<sup>34</sup> [Ernest Paradis], 'The "Zinyao" of Nyasaland: Devil Dancers of Terror', *East Africa*, 5(1928-9), pp. 837-8; anon., 'The "Zinyao" of Nyasaland: The Menace assuming Alarming Proportions', *East Africa*, 5(1928-9), p. 907.

<sup>35</sup> See Linden, *Catholics*, pp. 125, 131; the Lindens, however, concerned with the *nyau* as peasant resistance to Catholic missionary endeavour, do not fully explore the other implications of the societies' post-war activities.

With the Great War, European power had been made shockingly manifest in every part of Nyasaland as never before. Nothing would be the same. African society was evermore to be entangled with European ways of life. Once again, though, the Chewa showed their resilience. Especially in the traditional religious institution of the *nyau* societies they proved their culture, even if in an adapted form, could survive the severest tests.